


ARUN KUMAR

**ALL ABLAZE**
AAP workers protest Arvind Kejriwal's arrest in Delhi, Mar. 24

voters who backed AAP in 2020 would not have voted for the party if he was not the chief ministerial face. AAP received 54 per cent of the vote share in 2020, so the stakes are very high.

## BLESSINGS IN DISGUISE?

AAP leaders argue that Kejriwal's arrest could, in fact, galvanise party workers to unite and also garner massive public sympathy, resulting in a better electoral performance. Signals from the ground, though, remain ambivalent. "The streets of India, at the moment, have not reflected any concern over the ED actions against Opposition leaders. Most voters are unlikely to make a decision based on Kejriwal's arrest," says Prof. Narender Kumar.

Political analysts believe public sympathy will also depend on how the judiciary, particularly the SC, responds to Kejriwal's arrest. "If he manages to get bail before Delhi goes to the polls on May 25 and Punjab on June 1, he'll play martyr to perfection and the party will gain electorally," says Prof. Ashutosh Kumar of Panjab University.

Meanwhile, Kejriwal's wife Sunita has been making regular video appearances on social media, with emotional appeals to voters. There is speculation that she could take the party's mantle if the Delhi CM remains behind bars. But that will make Kejriwal appear no different from the regular politicians he charges with nepotism.

**THE BJP HAS FOUND IT DIFFICULT TO ATTACK KEJRIWAL ON HIS PERFORMANCE RECORD, SO IT IS TARGETING HIS ANTI-CORRUPTION CRUSADER IMAGE**

An immediate fallout of Kejriwal's arrest has been the closing of ranks by the Opposition I.N.D.I.A. bloc. Among the partners, the Congress hopes to use the AAP leader's arrest as a rallying point to bolster its electoral campaign, at least in Delhi. However, the party's eagerness to back AAP has put its workers in Punjab in a spot. AAP and Congress are the primary rivals in the state and the central leadership's move has denied the state unit a ready-made campaign narrative. "The only party that could have gained from Kejriwal's arrest in Punjab is the Congress," points out Prof. Ashutosh Kumar.

Meanwhile, the BJP is unlikely to sit idle, knowing well that Kejriwal's party will go all guns blazing to project his arrest as a political conspiracy. AAP's focus on healthcare, schools, subsidies on power and water bills and efficient delivery of services has created a strong pool of beneficiaries in Delhi and Punjab, who are likely to back the party. The BJP has found it difficult to attack Kejriwal on his performance record, so it has built a narrative targeting his anti-corruption crusader image. The party's internal surveys in Delhi reportedly found that the issue resonates with people. Sources say it is working on a 400-day strategy (keeping in mind the assembly polls next year) to corner Kejriwal and AAP on "10 specific scams".

Kejriwal has in the past decade weathered several political crises, often handling them with unconventional responses. The core of his political strategy has been the smart use of communication through traditional and social media. His arrest silences his voice just before the polls, and puts the electoral future of AAP at stake. The political maverick, who has thrived on disruptive discourses, will need luck and legal support to fight back. The next year will be make or break for him and AAP. ■